



Asif Zardari emerges as the real power in Pakistan after his election as President. With rising militancy and a flailing economy, his task is cut out. The doubt: Is he really cut out for the task?

■ **By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi**

Clad in a dapper blue pin-stripe suit and diamond-patterned necktie, hair gelled back and a broad smile on his face, Asif Zardari acknowledged the assembled dignitaries—including Afghan President Hamid Karzai—as he entered the Darbar Hall on the fifth floor of Islamabad's presidential palace on September 9. A few minutes later, he took oath from Chief Justice Abdul Hameed Dogar—the man whom former president General Pervez Musharraf had installed as head of a truncated judiciary last November and whom Zardari has also protected, to the chagrin of civil society activists—as the 12th President of Pakistan.

It has been a long and strange journey for a man dubbed by the late Benazir Bhutto as “the Mandela of Pakistan” for his long spells of incarceration on unproven corruption and murder charges, and a “plunderer of national coffers” by his detractors.

Vilified as “Mr Ten Per Cent” during his two stints in power under the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) governments in the 1990s, Zardari had often been blamed for the political disaster that befell Bhutto in power. But he also earned the grudging admiration of many for his steadfastness and loyalty to her and the party during his time in jail (1996-2004). But even until just eight-and-a-half months ago, before his wife's tragic assassination on December 27, 2007, nobody could have imagined that he would one day be referred to as “President Zardari”.

As he demonstrated over the past eight months, Zardari, however, is a master politician and knows the art of political wheeling and dealing. He neutralised his main opponent, former premier Nawaz Sharif, by cajoling him into a coalition government with PPP after the February 18 elections, but continued to use delaying tactics about his partner's agenda to restore the judiciary sacked by Musharraf while paying it lip service himself. When Sharif gave

an ultimatum, he persuaded him that all hindrances would be removed if their mutual nemesis, Musharraf, was ousted from presidency. To achieve this task, he built secret inroads with US neocon insiders such as Zalmay Khalilzad, who helped convince Bush administration officials to withdraw their support to their longtime point-man in the region. Meanwhile, Zardari continued shoring up support from other smaller parties and independents using a combination of promises and immediate benefits. By the time Sharif finally pulled out of the coalition government in frustration, Zardari had garnered enough outside support to ensure that the PPP Government survived and his own ascent to the presidency—unmentioned publicly as a possibility until Musharraf resigned—was a cinch. In the elections held on September 6, Zardari bagged 481 out of the 702 electoral college votes, far more than the required 352.

But Zardari inherits a troubled mantle and faces problems that one